Prussian uniform
The army built up by Frederick William I and used so effectively by his son Frederick II was always beautifully turned out. Most infantry regiments wore long, dark blue coats with red facings and lining.

Flintlock carbine
The principal weapon was the standard flintlock musket of the day. Prussian muskets were well-made and generally reliable. This example is a rifled carbine, used by cuirassiers and dragoons, dating from 1722.



COSSACK

After the major European powers had created their strictly controlled 18th-century armies, they were forced to turn to the untamed ethnic groups that lived on the extreme margins of their territories in search of men who could act with individual initiative as scouts and skirmishers. Austria's Grenzer sharpshooters from Croatia and Slovenia were one example; Russia's Cossack horsemen were another.

The Cossack communities of the southern steppe seem mostly to have been founded by freedom-loving Slavs who fled the rapidly expanding kingdoms of Russia and Poland-Lithuania in the 15th and 16th centuries, preferring a hard but independent life to serfdom. Out of harsh necessity they became warrior bands, fighting as light horsemen in the traditional way of the steppe. Much of the time they would fight against both Russia and Poland, asserting their independence. At other times they acted as semi-independent frontier forces, raiding Ottoman territories in search of plunder, or fighting on behalf of the Tsars, guarding Russia from attack by the Tatars and helping to extend the borders of the Russian Empire further to the east.

SERVING THE STATE

In the course of the 18th century, tens of thousands of Cossack were integrated into the Russian imperial army as light cavalry regiments. In addition to their traditional swords and knives, their principal weapons were a musket or rifle, used chiefly for defence, and a long slender lance with which they would charge enemy positions in loose fast-moving lines. Their savage skill at harassing the flanks of an enemy on the march or running down fleeing infantrymen made them much feared and respected. In 1775, Russian Marshal Rumyantzev recognized the Cossacks' courage in war with the Ottoman Turks, describing them as "the first into the fire, distinguishing themselves with outstanding bravery".



Kindjal
This long, curved knife originated in the Caucasus, from where it was adopted by the Cossacks along with the shashka, a kind of sabre. Russian troops were issued with kindjals of this type as late as World War I.